some of my summer lifeguard earnings and was happy to send her $50. She asked me not to tell Jack about it and I never did.

Subsequently, Jack found a job as manager and sole clerk of a chain store shoe outlet near Springfield, two hundred miles from Dixon and Nelle.

During the football season, our team stayed overnight in Springfield, and Moon and I talked Mac into letting us leave the hotel for a few hours to visit him. We found Jack in a run-down neighborhood at the edge of Springfield. His store was a grim, tiny hole-in-the-wall. Although he'd cleaned it up, there wasn't much anybody could have done with the store. There were garish orange advertisements promoting cut-rate shoes plastered on the windows, and the sole piece of furniture was a small wooden bench with iron armrests where his customers were fitted.

When I saw the store I thought of the hours he'd spent when we were boys talking about the grand shoe store he dreamed of opening one day, then remembered the Fashion Boot Shop, the elegant store that, before he lost it, had fulfilled his dream.

My eyes filled and I looked away, not wanting him to see the tears welling up in my eyes.

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Because a lot of Nelle's great sense of religious faith rubbed off on me, I have always prayed a lot; in those days, I prayed things would get better for our country, for our family, and for Dixon. I even prayed before football games.

I was the only player on our first string who'd come to Eureka directly from high school. Most of the other players were more mature and several were quite a bit older than I; after high school, they'd gone into the working world during the Roaring Twenties when jobs were plentiful, then, when